

Hollywood invading your PC?

In one of the boldest political efforts yet, movie studios have drawn up a bill to disrupt peer-to-peer networks to curb piracy. The bill permits copyright holders to perform nearly unchecked electronic hacking if they have a 'reasonable basis' to suspect piracy. In effect, this would immunise groups such as the Motion Picture Association of America (MPAA) and the Recording Industry Association of

America (RIAA) from all state and federal laws if they disable or block a peer-to-peer network. Anyone whose computer gets damaged in the process, must receive permis-

sion from the US Attorney General before filing a lawsuit, and the suit can be filed only if the actual monetary loss was more than \$250.

Concerns have been raised over the fact that unless you can show economic harm, you can't even be compensated. Even if you want to be compensated, you have to jump through procedural hoops. The MPAA however asserts that law-abiding Internet users should have no reason to be concerned.



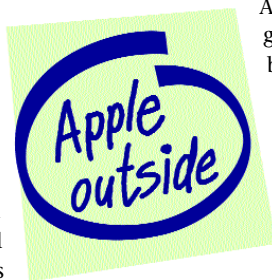
Apple may switch to Intel

Andrew Neff, an analyst with the US-based investment banking firm, Bear Stearns, predicts that Apple will shift to Intel chips. Apple currently uses the PowerPC chips from Motorola and IBM that max out at 1 GHz. Intel already has chips

running at 2.5 GHz, with 3 GHz due later this year. This move will give Apple's computers a great performance boost and in turn gain more customers.

When Steve Jobs was asked if Apple would consider a move from the Power-

PC architecture, he had replied, "...we like to have options." While Wall Street analysts have created a cottage industry out of making grandiose predictions and recommendations, Neff can boast of a fairly strong track record. In January 2001, he said that HP should purchase Compaq—months later HP announced it was buying Compaq.



redalert

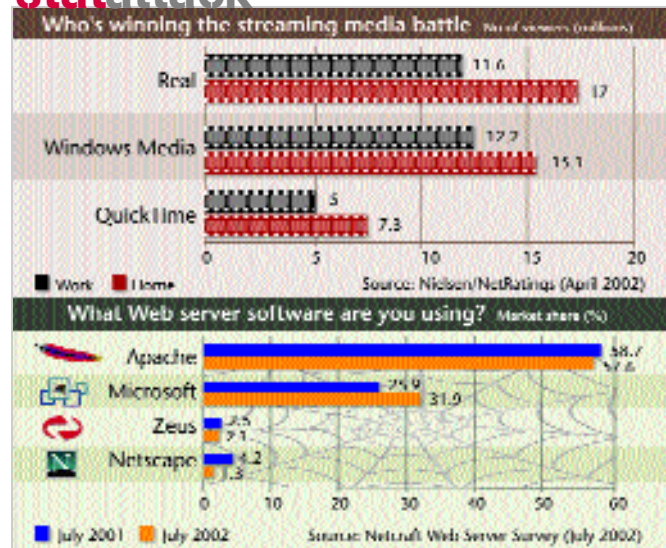
Trojan in encryption program

A Trojan horse turned OpenSSH, the *de facto* standard for network security, into a convenient back door. OpenSSH encrypts the link between two computers to prevent eavesdroppers from capturing messages as they are sent across the network. In the infected release, the Trojan attempts to communicate with other computers on the Internet and awaits further commands, giving complete control to potential hackers. How the Trojan was sneaked in as part of the update is unknown. The fake release has been replaced with one without the Trojan.

PHP vulnerable

The PHP form-data post handler is susceptible to a malicious post request that can trigger an error condition which, depending on the hardware, can crash the machine or provide access for remote exploitation. On an Intel x86 machine an attacker has no control over memory allocation and can only cause a Denial of Service (DoS), but on a Solaris machine, a hacker would be able to free chunks of memory and overwrite them arbitrarily to run code. PHP versions 4.2.0 and 4.2.1 are vulnerable. A fixed version as well as patches have been released to rectify the problem.

statattack



INFOGRAPHICS: Jaya Shetty

Two heads are better

Japanese company Scarabs has designed a two-headed hard drive that consists of a read/write head and a second read-only head to provide higher security. The latter will be connected to the Web server, while the former connects to the PC used to update the Web site. Both are completely independent, making it impossible for people viewing the site to hack it. It also means that the Web site can be updated without interrupting surfers, as changes can be made using the read/write head.

snapshot

Overall IT spending
in 2002:
\$981 billion

Source: IDC

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